of those one-eighth portions.[34] The problem, however, is that there is no large or substantial stupa here that can be considered Mauryan, nor have any relics been recovered at Lumbini. For the moment, therefore, it seems best to see Ashoka as having made a revenue concession, even if not a generous one!

Beyond such conflicting interpretations of the royal epigraph, most striking is the way in which memorialization was combined here with an overt expression of political power. The emperor recorded his visit when he came to worship at the place where the Buddha was born. At the same time, the pillar that he put up was of such monumental dimensions that it must have more or less eclipsed the original shrine. So the shrine too was renovated and expanded via royal patronage. The emperor then used the occasion to announce a reduction in agricultural taxes for Lumbini village. This is possibly the earliest documented example in South Asia of a political patron deploying a sacred landscape to announce revenue concessions. The example is multiplied in later times: there are plenty of examples of exemptions and privileges given by kings alongside endowments to religious establishments, including on occasion tax exemptions.[35]

The inscribing of Ashoka's presence here was followed by Ripu Malla more than 1600 years later. This king of the Naga dynasty made a pilgrimage to Lumbini in 1312 CE, where a Buddhist mantra—'Om Mani Padme Hum', or 'Hail to the jewel of the lotus'—was engraved along with his name on the very Ashoka pillar recording the emperor's pilgrimage.[36]

At Gotihawa can be seen the remnants of a pillar that Ashoka put up over perhaps the same tour.[37] Unlike the grass-covered stupa, only a small portion of the pillar is now visible. It used to be known as Phuteshwar Mahadeva—an appellation which suggests it was worshipped as a broken (or 'phuta') Shivalinga. In the late nineteenth century three pillar fragments, including a portion of the bell capital base, were also to be seen in the